

Accessories

Cell phones are no longer just communication devices; they reflect one's lifestyle and attitude, and this leaves a lot of space for customisation options such as add-on kits and other accessories. These accessories can be lifestyle-defining or they could simply enhance and simplify the overall cell phone experience.

These accessories can be classified into functional (those that improve the usability) and the non-functional (those that improve the aesthetics). Among the functional accessories we have various options such as headsets, music stands, music players, external video cameras, desktop chargers and batteries.

Headsets have been around for quite a while. They allow you to receive and make calls without your having to bring the phone near your ear. Just plug the earpiece in your ear, and your hands are free to do whatever mischief they're up to at the moment!

For business users who are always on the move, long battery life is always an advantage. But a having spare battery is equally good. Nearly all manufacturers today provide spare batteries and a desktop charger to charge them. Nokia even provides dif-

ferent types of chargers. The ACP 12E is the best of the lot—it reduces charging time by half.

You also get MP3 and FM radio sets that plug into your phone, and let you listen to music on the go. Nokia has an add-on MP3 adapter for most of its phones, whereas Sony Ericsson offers an FM radio kit for some of its models. Nokia has recently introduced its 'Music Stand', an audio device that sits on the desktop and lets you play music via built-in speakers.

With the advent of MMS and due support from service providers, manufacturers such as Nokia, Sony Ericsson, Motorola and Panasonic have introduced external cameras for some of their models. These plug into a port and let you use your cell phone for some decent—if clandestine—photography.

Apart from such functional accessories that make your life simpler and more organised, phone makers also offer colourful changeable covers for nearly all models. All Nokia models support this feature, and other manufacturers have introduced such features in their latest models. Some high-end models even sport an elegant leather carry case.



Power Tips

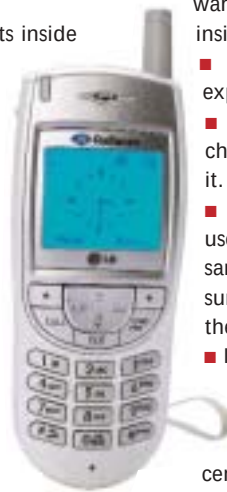
Phone Care

You just spend your hard earned money buying an expensive mobile phone, so make sure you keep the following points in your mind while handling them else you could end up damaging it in the long run.

- Never keep your cell phone near heat and magnetic sources (gas stove, direct sunlight, audio speakers, etc).
- Avoid dropping it as it could damage the delicate circuits inside the phone. Use a wrist strap or a belt clip. Covering your phone (and possibly making it look less attractive) is a more prudent choice than damaging it by dropping it.
- Switch the device off if it's not going to be used for a long period of time. If you do not tend to use your mobile phone for a long time, then remove the battery and put in a dry and a cool place.
- Keep the device away from moisture and liquids. Avoid taking the phone into areas like kitchens or washrooms. Avoid storing or using it in dusty, dirty areas as its moving parts can be damaged.
- While charging the device, do not pull the adapter cord out from the device until the main electricity supply is switched off.
- Switch off the phone before removing the battery or changing your SIM card.
- Use only approved accessories and batteries. Do not connect incompatible products. Always use the rated and factory specified accessories for your phone. If, for example, you use a higher power rating for charging your phone, it could get charged faster but will lower the life of the battery or even damage the phone.
- Ensure you keep your mobile and its accessories out of the reach

of children.

- Never forget your cell phone in your vehicle—apart from the fear of being stolen, the heat could shorten the life of electronic devices, damage batteries and melt certain plastic components. Similarly, do not store your phone in cold areas because when the phone warms up to its normal temperature, moisture can form inside it, which may damage the electronic circuit boards.
- Never attempt to open the phone yourself, as non-expert handling of the device may damage it.
- If you wish to clean your cell phones, do not use harsh chemicals, cleaning solvents, or strong detergents to clean it. Just take a soft moistened cloth to wipe off the dirt.
- A new battery usually lasts for two years provided you use it in the right way. Never recharge a battery unnecessarily, this in effect reduces the charge cycle. Always make sure you use the specified charger, else even this will affect the battery performance.
- In a country such as India, where temperature and humidity levels are high your phone may stop functioning in extreme cases. If this happens do not try to open the phone yourself instead give to the authorised service centre and they will do the needful.



Health and Safety Tips

- Never use your phone while driving. It may not be a punishable offence in many states, but you could cause an accident.
- As an alternative, you could use one of the many hands-free accessories available today, but be aware that using these while driving could also be an offence.